



Froot biodegradable, sustainable computer concept from Pauline Carlos uses a laser keyboard and screen projection technology

Netbook? I don't see the word in the dictionary!

"2009 can be named the year of the netbook! Netbooks have been able to open a niche market segment of casual computer users—primarily Internet surfers and executives looking for a lighter, no-frills PC for use during travel and business meetings. Thus, what has emerged is that there is a niche for a portable computing device with less powerful processing capabilities than provided in full-feature PCs but at a more attractive price point," says S. Rajendran, chief marketing officer, Acer India.

The relatively lower price points of netbooks compared to notebooks make them accessible to a wider population in India. The desktop equivalent of a netbook is called 'nettop.' Of late, netbooks are actually beginning to go beyond the casual user space, armed with touch screens and smaller form factors.

So, is the iPad a netbook?

The iPad probably fits the description of a tablet more than a netbook, although the company claims it is neither, being a singly-populated species incomparable with others. Add a touch screen or stylus operation to a fully-functional but small laptop, and you'll have a tablet. The tablets of today are not like the bulky ones of yesteryears. Sleek and smart, it is expected that ultra-thin tablet PCs, in the 17.8cm (7-inch) to 27.9cm (11-inch) screen-size range, will become the rage in the near future. The iPad is a 24.6cm (9.7-inch) screen tablet, less than 1.3cm (half an inch) thick.

then detach the screen and start using it as a tablet, continuing your work where you left it, without any interruption.

You can use the touch screen as a single-, four- or six-section display, and use its multi-touch capability to simultaneously work on multiple Web-based applications or view multiple media files in parallel.

Another interesting tabby-embedded device displayed at the CES was ASUS' Eee keyboard PC—a keyboard with all the functionality of a netbook. It comprises a regular-sized keyboard with a 12.7cm (5-inch) touchscreen embedded on its right side. Hidden within this simple device is a 1.6GHz processor, 1 GB of DDR2 memory and a built-in battery that can run for up to four hours. The display acts as a touchpad and can be used for widgets such as calendar, time, weather, news and email notification. You can attach an external screen if you wish to run a regular operating system.

Both the devices are expected to launch sometime this year.

4 Portability for desktops

Industrial designer Pauline Carlos' entry to Dell's sustainable PC design contest is a tiny computer with two pico-projectors—one projects the output (acting as a monitor) and the other a keypad (acting as a keyboard). In short, this small, portable instrument becomes a standalone, full-fledged desktop computer. The gadget is made of a biodegradable starch-based polymer.

No mouse? Well, analysts guess that since it is a futuristic concept, the designer probably felt that we would be using brain-computer interfaces by then!

5 Innovations galore

A year ago, a group of students from Carnegie Mellon University, USA, demonstrated a touchscreen adaptation that had keys pop up from it when the user started typing.

Now, a Portuguese company